

GOLD STANDARD EXAMPLE 1:

STAYNOW PLATFORM RESEARCH

Research Synthesis

— Guest Formative Study Study: StayNow - Online Travel Booking Platform Participants: 10 Guests (P1 - P10) Methodology: Moderated Remote Interviews (Interview + Simulated Booking) Section 1: Insights INSIGHT 1 Trust in independent hotels is a platform problem, not a hotel quality problem Guests across the study consistently expressed willingness — and in several cases preference — for boutique and independent hotels over chains, yet defaulted to chains when trust signals were absent. The platforms responsible for surfacing independent properties have failed to create the informational infrastructure that would allow guests to extend trust with confidence. The trust deficit is not about independent hotel quality; it is about the gap between what a listing communicates and what a guest needs to know before committing. Until that gap is closed at the platform level, risk-averse guests will continue to choose the predictability of chains over the preference they already have for independent properties. Observations

- All 10 participants cited predictability or reliability as the reason chains retain a booking advantage over independent hotels, despite 8 of 10 expressing a personal preference for boutique properties — [P1, 00:53:40], [P2, 00:53:30], [P3, 00:54:00], [P4, 00:53:40], [P5, 00:54:00], [P6, 00:53:40], [P7, 00:54:00], [P8, 00:53:50], [P9, 00:54:00], [P10, 00:53:45]
- Participants described independent hotel listings as lacking the standardised floor of information that chain hotel listings provide — [P1, 00:53:40], [P3, 00:55:15], [P7, 00:54:00]
- Six participants mentioned having been burned at least once by an independent hotel that did not match its listing — [P2, 00:41:45], [P3, 00:26:20], [P7, 00:42:30], [P9, 00:38:35]
- P4 spontaneously distinguished between official star ratings and guest review scores as separate trust signals, saying stars are a hotel self-assessment — [P4, 00:12:30]
- P9 noted the boutique independent hotel label has been diluted by bad actors and that guests cannot distinguish genuine from performative without third-party validation — [P9, 00:54:00]

Supporting Quotes "Boutique hotels are a gamble. Until a platform makes them as predictable as Marriott, risk-averse guests will always choose a chain." — P1, 00:53:40 "I've had too many boutique hotels not meet the listing promise. Chains at least deliver a known baseline." — P3, 00:55:15 "The boutique independent label has been diluted by bad actors. We need third-party validation." — P9, 00:54:00 Recommendations

- Explore what a minimum information standard for independent hotel listings on StayNow would look like

— one that gives guests the same baseline confidence they get from chain hotels, without requiring chains. • Consider how third-party validation or verification signals could be surfaced on listings to help guests distinguish genuine independent hotels from those that misuse the label. Mapped Research Questions – [Journey] What are the pain points in their journey? – [Decision-making] How do guests make a decision on which hotel to book? – [Driving Adoption] Why will people come to StayNow and no other OTA? – [Trust] How do you build trust on the booking experience? INSIGHT 2 Photo quality and accuracy are the first — and often final — decision filter Guests treat photos not as supplementary information but as the primary trust proxy for the entire listing because no other signal communicates the real character of an independent hotel as efficiently, and guests have learned that photo manipulation is common enough to be expected rather than exceptional. The consequence is bifurcated: high-quality, honest photography accelerates the booking decision, while manipulated or low-quality imagery creates lasting doubt about the property's management standards. Observations ◦ P2 stated she eliminates properties in the first 3 seconds based on photos alone, before reading any text — [P2, 00:13:10] ◦ P9 stated blurry photos equal blurry management and will not book a property with poor photography — [P9, 00:13:40] ◦ Three participants independently noted that wide-angle lens distortion made rooms appear larger than they were — [P1, 00:38:00], [P3, 00:36:10], [P7, 00:42:30] ◦ P1 discovered on arrival that his vineyard view was a parking lot with a distant vineyard — technically accurate but deliberately misleading — [P1, 00:38:00] ◦ P7 cited photo and review accuracy as the primary barrier preventing guests from returning to independent hotels after a bad experience — [P7, 00:54:00] ◦ P2 chose a hotel at 30% above her budget because the photos delivered exactly what she needed for her creative retreat — [P2, 00:26:00] Supporting Quotes "I eliminate properties in the first 3 seconds based on photos alone. The photos ARE the product." — P2, 00:13:10 "Blurry photos equal blurry management. I won't book a property with bad photography." — P9, 00:13:40 "The listing was technically accurate but deliberately misleading. The vineyard view was a parking lot." — P1, 00:38:00 Recommendations • Explore what a photo accuracy standard for StayNow listings would look like — one that gives guests confidence that what they see reflects what they will find. • Consider how guests could be given a more honest view of what they are booking — particularly for features like views, room size, and proximity claims that are commonly misrepresented. Mapped Research Questions – [Decision-making] Which elements would they take into account to make a decision? – [Ideal Experience] What is the guest's ideal end to end journey? – [Trust] How to build trust on the booking experience? INSIGHT 3 Hidden fees and cross-platform price inconsistency destroy booking confidence at the moment of commitment Guests across the study encountered pricing that appeared to misrepresent the true cost of a booking — either by revealing fees only at checkout or by displaying different prices across platforms for the

same property. This pattern has trained guests to distrust displayed prices, adding an anxiety layer to the final booking step that erodes confidence in both the platform and the property. The effect is amplified for price-sensitive guests, who must absorb the additional cost of checking multiple platforms as a tax on the system's dishonesty. Observations

- P1 described nearly booking a hotel that was 40% more expensive than the listed rate once taxes and fees were added — [P1, 00:17:30]
- P5 described a consistent pattern of comparison tools showing lower prices that do not match the final booking price, calling it a bait-and-switch — [P5, 00:17:50]
- P5 explicitly stated he has no platform loyalty — only price loyalty — and uses comparison tools as a standard habit — [P5, 00:07:00]
- P9 identified manipulative scarcity signals as a specific trust-destroying tactic — [P9, 00:19:00]
- Multiple participants named total price transparency as a top feature of their ideal booking platform — [P1, 00:52:00], [P3, 00:52:30], [P5, 00:52:00]

Supporting Quotes

- "I've nearly booked a hotel 40% more expensive than listed once I added all the fees. Show me the total price." — P1, 00:17:30
- "Kayak shows me 80, I click through and it's 10. That bait-and-switch destroys trust." — P5, 00:17:50
- "I've seen the same room available in 1 room for 3 weeks. It's not honest." — P9, 00:19:00

Recommendations

- Show guests the full cost of a booking from the first moment they see a price — not at the final checkout step. This is a direct fix to a clearly named trust problem.
- Explore how StayNow can give guests confidence they are seeing a fair and accurate price, so the platform becomes a source of pricing trust rather than another source of uncertainty.

Mapped Research Questions – [Journey] What are the pain points of the search experience? – [Decision-making] Is price difference something important when shortlisting? – [Trust] What drives trust on the booking experience? – [Driving Adoption] What do we need to offer to entice them to use a new platform?

INSIGHT 4 Guests use multi-platform search not from preference but from compensating for individual platform inadequacy

Most participants used two or more platforms as part of a single booking decision — not because they preferred a multi-platform experience, but because no single platform delivered everything they needed to feel confident. Each tool in the current ecosystem excels at one function: Kayak for price calibration, TripAdvisor for editorial signals, Booking.com for browsing, Google Hotels for map-first location context. Guests have learned to chain them together as a workaround. StayNow has a structural opportunity to collapse this multi-step journey into a single surface, directly competing with the combined utility of the tools participants currently stitch together.

Observations

- P3 used Kayak for price range calibration, then Booking.com for individual property decisions — explicitly naming each tool's distinct role — [P3, 00:11:45]
- P7 started on TripAdvisor for quality signals, then moved to Booking.com for price and availability — [P7, 00:12:00]
- P8 opened Expedia and Booking.com simultaneously in two tabs to compare prices before committing — [P8, 00:11:45]
- P10 opened Google Hotels first for map context, then moved to Booking.com

for the specific property — [P10, 00:11:30] ◦ P2 performed a Google search for boutique hotel editorial recommendations before entering any OTA — [P2, 00:11:00] ◦ P6 messaged properties directly before booking when the listing did not answer her specific workspace questions — [P6, 00:25:30] Supporting Quotes "Kayak is for calibration. Booking is for decision-making. They're two different tools for two different jobs." — P3, 00:11:45 "I trust TripAdvisor for quality signals, then I book wherever it's cheapest." — P7, 00:12:00 "I always open Google Maps before I open any booking platform. Location is everything." — P10, 00:06:50 Recommendations • Explore how StayNow can reduce the need for guests to leave the platform to answer a question that should be answerable in one place — whether that is price context, editorial quality signals, or neighbourhood information. • Consider how pre-booking communication between guests and hotels could be brought into the platform, capturing the direct contact behaviour that currently happens outside it.

Mapped Research Questions – [Journey] What is the booking journey? Where do they go to book? – [Decision-making] Where do people search for hotels? How do people search? – [Driving Adoption] Why will people come to StayNow and not another OTA? – [Ideal Experience] What is the guest's ideal end-to-end journey? INSIGHT 5 Cancellation flexibility is a proxy for emotional commitment — not just a policy preference Multiple participants described free cancellation not as a backup plan but as a psychological prerequisite for initiating the booking at all because the act of booking an independent hotel carries higher perceived risk than booking a chain, and free cancellation functions as an emotional safety net that lowers the cost of a wrong decision. Guests who have flexible cancellation book faster, with less deliberation, and with greater willingness to try unfamiliar independent properties — making cancellation policy a direct lever on platform conversion rates. Observations ◦ P6 applied free cancellation as her first filter — before price, star rating, or location — stating it was non-negotiable — [P6, 00:11:30] ◦ P6 disclosed she had not fully committed to the trip when booking, and free cancellation enabled her to proceed under that uncertainty — [P6, 00:16:30] ◦ P9 stated he always books refundable rates, which means reservation changes feel low-stakes — [P9, 00:29:40] ◦ P8 requires free cancellation as a corporate expense compliance standard — free cancellation is simultaneously a personal preference and an institutional requirement — [P8, 00:14:15] ◦ P4 found the cancellation change process smooth but stressful because she was not sure the hotel received the change confirmation — [P4, 00:29:30] ◦ P6's refund process after a health cancellation required 8 days and 3 follow-up emails — described as exhausting — [P6, 00:29:30] Supporting Quotes "I always book refundable. Changes feel low-stakes when you're not risking money." — P9, 00:29:40 "I hadn't fully committed to Napa. Refundable was non-negotiable." — P6, 00:16:30 "The cancellation policies are written in legal language that requires a law degree." — P6, 00:18:30 Recommendations • Make cancellation terms immediately visible and understandable at

the listing level — not buried in fine print at checkout. Guests should not have to work to understand what they are committing to. • Explore how modification and cancellation confidence can be built into the booking experience, so guests feel secure making a reservation rather than anxious about what happens if things change. Mapped Research Questions – [Journey] How often do people change their reservation? – [Journey] What are the pain points in their journey? – [Ideal Experience] What is the check-in experience expectation? – [Trust] How do you build trust on the booking experience? INSIGHT 6 Guests treat platforms as infrastructure during the stay — and human contact as the trust layer for exceptions Participants consistently described turning away from platform-mediated channels when their needs became complex or time-sensitive during and around the stay... because digital platforms have not yet proven reliable in high-stakes moments — modifications, early check-in, accessibility requests, corporate invoice corrections — and guests have learned that direct hotel contact resolves problems faster. The result is a predictable pattern: low-complexity transactions stay on the platform; high-complexity or emotionally significant interactions shift to phone or email. This represents both a trust gap and a product opportunity for StayNow. Observations • P7 called the hotel directly for a stay extension, stating she did not trust platform modifications and preferred to talk to a person — [P7, 00:29:10] • P1 contacted the hotel by email for a check-in date change, explicitly bypassing the platform because he did not trust it would communicate properly with the hotel — [P1, 00:29:30] • P8 called Expedia customer service for a room block reduction and waited 45 minutes — [P8, 00:29:35] • P10 made 3 phone calls to hotels before booking because the platform could not answer her accessibility questions — [P10, 00:29:00] • P6 messaged the hotel directly pre-booking to confirm workspace quality — the hotel responded with a speed test screenshot, which triggered her booking within 5 minutes — [P6, 00:26:50] • P3 noted the platform offers no mechanism for requesting a room upgrade pre-arrival, forcing an awkward in-person request at check-in — [P3, 00:29:45] Supporting Quotes "The platform is fine when nothing goes wrong. It's a nightmare when something does." — P8, 00:29:00 "I don't trust platform modifications. I'd rather talk to a person." — P7, 00:29:10 "The hotel sent me a speed test screenshot. I booked within 5 minutes." — P6, 00:26:50 Recommendations • Explore how StayNow can give guests confidence that changes and requests made through the platform will actually reach the hotel and be acted on — closing the gap that is currently pushing guests to call or email directly. • Consider how the pre-booking and pre-arrival period could be better supported, so guests can get specific questions answered without having to leave the platform. Mapped Research Questions – [Journey] How often and why do people go to support? – [Journey] What method of checking in is most desirable? – [Ideal Experience] What makes a good or bad support experience? – [Ideal Experience] What is the check-in experience expectation? INSIGHT 7 Loyalty programmes create more distrust than loyalty

when redemption fails to deliver Participants who engaged with hotel or OTA loyalty programmes described them as intellectually appealing but practically disappointing — with two recurring failure modes: redemption friction (restrictions that make 'free' nights effectively paid) and inconsistency of perk delivery because the loyalty programme promise is emotional ('you'll be rewarded') while the redemption experience is administrative ('terms and conditions apply'), and the gap between these two experiences registers as deception rather than disappointment. The result is that a failed loyalty interaction leaves guests more mistrustful than if no programme existed. Observations ◦ P5 described her loyalty free night as having so many restrictions she had to pay anyway — I felt deceived — [P5, 00:49:10] ◦ P6 described Booking.com Genius room upgrades as valuable when they materialise, citing inconsistency as undermining trust — [P6, 00:49:30] ◦ P7 reported Hilton Honors points expired before she could use them — I did not bother after that — [P7, 00:49:50] ◦ P2 described loyalty programme fragmentation: small balances across 6 programmes, each too small to redeem — [P2, 00:49:10] ◦ P4 found Booking.com Genius discounts real but requiring friction to activate — the friction of using it undermined the value of having it — [P4, 00:49:30] ◦ P10 named the need for a cross-platform independent hotel loyalty programme that follows her across property types, not one that locks her into a chain — [P10, 00:49:35] Supporting Quotes "The free night had so many restrictions I had to pay anyway. I felt deceived." — P5, 00:49:10 "The discounts were real but small, and I had to remember to be logged in. The friction undermined the value." — P4, 00:49:30 "I need a loyalty programme that follows me across property types — not one that locks me into a chain." — P10, 00:49:00 Recommendations • Explore what a loyalty model built around independent hotels would look like — one that rewards guests for staying across different properties on the platform rather than requiring loyalty to a single chain or brand. • Any loyalty programme StayNow introduces should make its benefits easy to understand and easy to use. Complexity and hidden restrictions are what turn the current programmes from assets into liabilities. Mapped Research Questions – [Driving Loyalty] What drives customer loyalty in a platform and in a hotel? – [Driving Loyalty] Are customers interested in points? – [Perks] Which perks would make users come back to StayNow? – [Driving Adoption] What will drive guests to choose one OTA over another? INSIGHT 8 Review behaviour is driven by peer utility and provocation — not platform prompts Participants who leave reviews do so primarily to help future travellers like themselves — not in response to platform requests because the motivation to write a review is linked to a sense of civic contribution or correction of record, and platform-timed review prompts undermine this motivation by making the act feel compelled rather than voluntary. Premature review prompts (such as appearing before the guest has left the property) were explicitly called out as manipulative, damaging the post-stay relationship with the platform at a moment when advocacy is most available. Observations ◦ P1

described writing reviews as a civic duty and did so within 48 hours unprompted — [P1, 00:46:45] ◦ P6 left a specific review about the workspace ergonomics issue to warn future solo workers — [P6, 00:46:45] ◦ P10 left an accessibility review specifically because future guests with mobility needs need to know — [P10, 00:46:50] ◦ P6 flagged a review prompt that appeared on the checkout screen before she had left the building as manipulative — [P6, 00:44:10] ◦ P5 intended to write a review but forgot — noting a reminder at 3 days post-checkout would likely have prompted him — [P5, 00:47:05] ◦ P3 writes reviews only for extreme experiences — great or awful — average stays stay private — [P3, 00:47:00] ◦ P2 posted to Instagram instead of writing a platform review, expressing a preference for linking that post as her review — [P2, 00:46:30]

Supporting Quotes "I write reviews because I read reviews. It's a civic duty." — P1, 00:46:45 "The review prompt appeared before I'd left the building. That felt manipulative." — P6, 00:44:10 "If the platform had sent me a reminder at exactly the right time — like 3 days after checkout — I might have done it." — P5, 00:47:05

Recommendations • Prompt guests to leave a review at a moment that feels natural rather than pressured — well after the stay, when reflection has had time to form. • Explore whether the review experience could better serve the specific motivations guests already have — such as warning future travellers about specific issues, or highlighting aspects of a stay that standard review categories miss.

Mapped Research Questions – [Driving Loyalty] What makes you write a review? – [Driving Loyalty] In what case would you recommend the hotel? – [Driving Loyalty] What will motivate you to share your experience? – [Driving Adoption] How do we make guests change the OTA they use?

INSIGHT 9 Guests self-segment into distinct traveller types whose platform needs are mutually incompatible with a single generic OTA experience. The study surfaced four distinct traveller modes — business traveller, solo remote worker, group booker, and accessibility-priority traveller — each with acute, non-overlapping needs that a generic booking platform cannot simultaneously serve. The criteria these segments use to evaluate a successful booking differ fundamentally: business travellers optimise for policy compliance and predictability; solo workers optimise for workspace quality and digital-first experience; group bookers require group-aware infrastructure; and accessibility-priority travellers require verified physical detail that current listings universally under-deliver. A platform that attempts to serve all four with a single undifferentiated experience will fail all four. The data suggests that the guests most underserved by existing platforms — groups, corporate bookers, accessibility travellers, remote workers — represent a significant and addressable opportunity for StayNow.

Observations ◦ P8 makes every booking decision through a corporate policy compliance filter — personal preference is irrelevant — [P8, 00:15:30] ◦ P6 messaged hotels pre-booking with a self-developed workspace quality checklist — a gap she filled herself because no platform provided the information — [P6, 00:25:00] ◦ P5 noted that most platforms design for 2 people multiple times — group dynamics made

every stage of the booking journey more complex — [P5, 00:40:00] ◦ P10 made 3 phone calls before booking because the platform could not answer her parents' accessibility questions — [P10, 00:29:00] ◦ P5 encountered a platform limitation when trying to register multiple check-in times for group members arriving separately — [P5, 00:30:00] ◦ P8 described independent hotels not making it onto corporate preferred lists because they cannot offer corporate pricing agreements — [P8, 00:53:50] Supporting Quotes "The group booking experience is broken on every platform. Fix that and I'm loyal forever." — P5, 00:53:20 "Solo workers default to business hotels because the workspace is guaranteed. Independent hotels are a wildcard." — P6, 00:53:40 "Build for the corporate booker and you solve 30% of my problems automatically." — P8, 00:53:15 Recommendations • Explore how StayNow's search and booking experience could adapt to the type of trip a guest is taking, rather than presenting the same experience to everyone regardless of their context. • Consider what it would take to make StayNow viable for traveller segments that currently default to chains or other platforms — specifically groups, corporate bookers, solo remote workers, and guests with accessibility needs — as each represents a distinct and underserved opportunity. Mapped Research Questions – [Journey] What is the barrier to entry for guests? – [Ideal Experience] What is the current independent hotel experience? – [Driving Adoption] Who are this small group of people interested in decentralised hotel booking? – [Perks] What do StayNow need to offer to make them desirable? Section 2: Key Findings The following findings capture structured, factual, or lightly synthesised data from the research that complements the insights above. These findings describe observable patterns that are important for context but do not require the interpretive depth of the insight format. Key Finding 1 Platform Usage Landscape: Participants Use a Stack of Tools, Not a Single OTA No participant relied on a single platform across all booking tasks. The most common pattern was a 2–3 platform stack, with each tool serving a distinct role: • Booking.com — primary browsing and shortlisting platform for 7 of 10 participants. Used for photo browsing, review reading, and final booking — [P2, P3, P4, P5, P6, P7, P8, P9, P10] • Expedia — primary platform for 2 business-travel participants due to corporate expense requirements; also used as a comparison tab alongside Booking.com — [P1, P3, P8] • Kayak — used specifically for price range calibration before entering a booking platform; not used as a booking destination — [P3, P5] • Google Hotels — emerging as a map-first entry point for location-anchored searchers; P10 is actively transitioning toward it as her primary platform — [P10] • TripAdvisor — used as an editorial quality layer before moving to Booking.com for availability and price — [P7, P2 via Google search] • Instagram / social media — used by P2 as a primary aesthetic discovery channel before entering any booking platform; P4 used friend recommendations as a primary discovery channel — [P2, P4] Observations ◦ P9 uses all major platforms analytically and tracks loyalty programme ROI by platform — highest platform literacy in the cohort — [P9, 00:07:30] ◦ P6 uses direct

hotel website booking when available, citing fewer fees and direct accountability — [P6, 00:07:00] Supporting Quote "I've stayed in 300+ hotels. I know what I'm looking for in about 90 seconds on any listing." — P9, 00:07:00 Mapped Research Questions – [Decision-making] Where do people search for hotels? What is the distribution of sources? – [Journey] What is the booking journey? Key Finding 2 Decision Criteria Hierarchy: What Guests Actually Filter On Across the simulated booking exercise and past booking recollections, participants revealed a consistent sequence of decision criteria. While individual weighting varies by traveller type, the following priority order reflects the most frequently mentioned primary criteria: • Location and neighbourhood context — most commonly the first filter applied; for P10, neighbourhood safety was a continuous filter across the entire search — [P4, P6, P10] • Free cancellation — non-negotiable primary filter for P6 and P8; important secondary filter for P3 and P9 — [P6, P8, P3, P9] • Guest review score and volume — P3 noted that review volume matters as much as score; P7 ignores reviews over 1 year old — [P3, P7] • Price — primary sort criterion for P5; secondary for most participants once core criteria are met — [P5, P1, P3] • Photos — primary filter for P2 (3-second elimination); quality proxy for P9 — [P2, P9] • Perks and amenities — cited as the tiebreaker once core criteria are satisfied, not a primary filter — [P3, P1, P4]

Observations ◦ P4 spontaneously distinguished star ratings from guest scores as different trust signals — stars as hotel self-assessment vs. guest scores as peer validation — [P4, 00:12:30] ◦ P6 reads negative reviews before positive ones as a deliberate information strategy — [P6, 00:13:20] Mapped Research Questions – [Decision-making] Which elements would they take into account to make a decision? – [Decision-making] What criteria do they consider to shortlist a hotel? – [Decision-making] How important are ratings when guests are selecting a hotel? Key Finding 3 Payment Methods and Crypto Consideration All 10 participants use credit card as their primary or sole payment method. Chargeback protection is the non-negotiable trust mechanism cited for online hotel payments. The full payment landscape observed: • Credit card (Visa/Mastercard) — universal primary method; cited specifically for chargeback protection — [P1, P2, P3, P5, P6, P7, P9, P10] • Corporate card — P8's only payment method for business travel; receipt and invoice compliance are the defining constraints — [P8] • Apple Pay — used by P2 for speed and card number protection — [P2] • PayPal — used as a middle layer for refundable bookings — [P3, P9] • Klarna (deferred payment) — used by P9 for an expensive property and by P10 for a high-cost family booking. P10 described it as making a large booking feel manageable — [P9, P10] • Cryptocurrency — universally declined. Primary objections: lack of chargeback protection, price volatility, and the sense that it is experimental currency for an everyday transaction. P5 expressed conditional openness if the price were locked at booking and a discount offered — [P1, P2, P5, P6, P7] Supporting Quotes "Free cancellation combined with credit card chargeback rights means I have two

layers of protection. That's non-negotiable." — P6, 00:32:00 "No chargeback protection means no protection for me." — P1, 00:32:00 Mapped Research Questions – [Trust] What payment methods are trustworthy? – [Trust] What are the forms of payment guests use? – [Trust] Are guests interested in paying in tokens? What do people know about tokens?

GOLD STANDARD EXAMPLE 2:-

RALLYUP — DONOR FUNDRAISING EXPERIENCE STUDY Research Synthesis — Formative Research Study: RallyUp - Online Fundraising Platform Participants: 10 Donor (P1 - P10) - 5 one time donors, 5 recurring donors Methodology: Moderated Remote Interviews (Interview + Platform Testing - RallyUp) Section 1: Insights **INSIGHT 1** Mandatory account creation mid-checkout is the platform's highest-severity conversion barrier All 10 participants encountered mandatory account creation inside the checkout flow, and every participant expressed friction, surprise, or resistance at this step. The account prompt arrives after a donor has already committed to giving — the moment of highest psychological investment — and introduces an administrative gate that interrupts the act of generosity. Seven of 10 named it the most frustrating moment in the task. One participant timed out entirely and never received payment confirmation. Another participant named it a textbook anti-pattern and cited research showing guest checkout doubles conversion — the most credible critique of the platform in the study. Observations

- All 10 participants encountered mandatory account creation and all 10 expressed confusion, frustration, or resistance — [P1, 00:38:20], [P2, 00:37:55], [P3, 00:38:25], [P4, 00:38:20], [P5, 00:38:30], [P6, 00:38:20], [P7, 00:38:35], [P8, 00:38:20], [P9, 00:38:30], [P10, 00:38:20]
- P8 timed out during Task 1 and never received a payment confirmation — the most severe failure point of the study — [P8, 00:38:20]
- P10 stated she almost quit at the password step and would have abandoned with one more unexpected friction point — [P10, 00:38:20]
- P3 and P9 both named guest checkout as the expected modern convention — its absence is experienced as a platform standard violation — [P3, 00:38:25], [P9, 00:38:30]
- P2 believed he already had an account and was confused about whether he was logging in or creating a new one — [P2, 00:37:55]

Supporting Quotes "I shouldn't need a password to buy a ticket. This friction will cost them donors." — P1, 00:38:40 "Account creation mid-checkout is a textbook anti-pattern. Guest checkout doubles conversion — this is a known fact." — P5, 00:39:00 "I almost gave up at the password step. I've abandoned carts for less." — P10, 00:38:20 **Recommendations** • Give donors a way to

complete a transaction without creating an account. Account creation, if offered, should come after the donation is confirmed, not before. • Explore how to reduce the information required to complete a digital ticket purchase. Asking for details that feel irrelevant to the transaction erodes trust at the most critical moment. Mapped Research Questions – What about the experience made it easy or difficult to complete the transaction? – Where does RallyUp meet or not meet donor expectations? – Where can we simplify the experience?

INSIGHT 2 Live event mechanics drive higher engagement and larger gifts than any other platform feature — but RallyUp’s live experience is incomplete Participants who attended virtual live fundraising events consistently reported giving more, staying longer, and feeling more connected to the cause than through static donation pages. The live format activates a fundamentally different psychological state — one driven by real-time social participation, competitive energy, and collective momentum rather than individual deliberation. Few participants explicitly stated they gave more at live events. However, RallyUp’s current live experience does not yet deliver the elements participants consistently described as essential: an integrated stream-and-bidding experience in one place, a real-time goal meter, a live donor feed, and a countdown timer per auction item. The gap between what the live format can achieve and what the platform currently provides is the largest single product opportunity identified in this study. Observations

- P1, P5, and P9 explicitly stated that live events produce larger donations than static donation pages — [P1, 00:05:10], [P5, 00:05:25], [P9, 00:05:25]
- P6’s countdown timer drove an unplanned bid — the competitive mechanic produced giving behaviour that deliberate intent would not have — [P6, 00:05:00]
- P4 donated in the moment during a livestream and stated she would not have given as much if she had done it later — [P4, 00:12:00]
- P1 and P5 both described the two-tab experience (stream + bidding in separate windows) as the primary pain point of their best live event — [P1, 00:13:15], [P5, 00:13:45]
- P3 described the best online event she attended as having integrated bidding, real-time total, polished production, and a 48-hour impact recap — and named the absence of any one element as degrading the whole — [P3, 00:24:20]

Supporting Quotes "The countdown timer got me — I placed a bid I hadn’t planned to just to win." — P6, 00:05:00 "I give more at live events than on static donation pages. The energy is contagious, even online." — P9, 00:05:25 "The multi-device experience worked, but it was clearly an accident, not a design decision." — P5, 00:13:45

Recommendations • Explore what it would take to bring the stream, bidding, and donation experience into a single unified event space so donors are never forced to split their attention across tools or tabs. • Investigate how urgency and competition mechanics — such as countdown timers and visible bidding activity — can be made a consistent part of the live event experience rather than an exception. Mapped Research Questions – What is the donor’s mental model for an auction, raffle and/or live event? – What past events have left a good impression and why? – What are undiscovered

opportunities we should pursue? – What compels donors to participate in a fundraiser?

INSIGHT 3 The donor journey ends at the receipt — but donors do not feel complete until they see the impact of their gift The platform currently ends the donor relationship at the confirmation receipt, but for most participants this is not where the emotional journey concludes. Donors described the post-event silence as a gap that leaves the giving experience unresolved. For recurring donors especially, knowing what happened with their money is not a nice-to-have — it is what determines whether they give again. Observations

- P5 stated she does not feel done until she receives a post-event impact report — [P5, 00:14:20]
- P1 received a personalised thank-you video from beneficiaries and described crying and telling everyone — the only unprompted advocacy event in the study — [P1, 00:23:00]
- P1, P3, P7, and P9 all named weak post-event follow-up as a top-three frustration — consistent across both new and recurring donors — [P1, 00:25:40], [P3, 00:26:50], [P7, 00:26:55], [P9, 00:26:50]
- P6 stated that being told how much was raised would have made him feel better about his contribution — [P6, 00:13:10]
- P9 follows organisations on social media for weeks post-event consuming impact updates — engagement captured by Instagram, not by RallyUp — [P9, 00:14:20]
- P8 received no receipt directly — it went to his wife — leaving him with no individual closure of his transaction — [P8, 00:13:40]

Supporting Quotes "I don't feel done until I know what happened with my money. The impact report closed the loop." — P5, 00:14:20 "It was the first time I truly felt the impact of giving. I cried. I told everyone about it." — P1, 00:23:00 "A 48-hour impact update would change how I feel about the whole experience." — P1, 00:55:20

Recommendations

- Explore how RallyUp can extend the donor experience beyond the transaction — giving donors a way to see what their contribution achieved, even if it is as simple as a total raised and a message from the organisation.
- Ensure every donor who participates receives individual confirmation of their contribution directly, regardless of how they were referred to the campaign.

Mapped Research Questions – What compels donors to participate or not participate in a fundraiser (across all stages)? – What is the best fundraising experience from the donor's perspective? – What are undiscovered opportunities we should pursue?

INSIGHT 4 RallyUp builds transactional trust through UX quality but lacks the brand-level trust that unfamiliar donors require before submitting payment In the mockup comparison, 6 of 10 participants rated UNICEF as more trustworthy, all citing brand recognition as the reason. Three rated RallyUp more trustworthy specifically for completing a transaction, pointing to design quality as what made the difference at the payment step. This reveals two distinct trust layers at play: brand trust, which answers whether the organisation is legitimate, and transactional trust, which answers whether it is safe to pay. RallyUp performs well on transactional trust but has not yet established brand-level recognition. For donors encountering the platform for the first time, that gap can be enough to cause them to stop before completing their

donation. Observations ◦ 6 of 10 participants rated UNICEF as more trustworthy, all citing brand recognition as the primary reason — [P1, P2, P6, P7, P8, P10] ◦ 3 participants rated RallyUp as more trustworthy for the specific act of completing a transaction, distinguishing brand trust from transactional UX trust — [P3, P5, P9] ◦ P2 stated he would Google RallyUp before giving them his card — a verification step that happens outside the platform and represents a dropout risk — [P2, 00:53:20] ◦ P4 and P9 both described RallyUp's design quality as a proxy for organisational quality — [P4, 00:53:45], [P9, 00:53:55] ◦ P10 stated she would want more verification signals before providing payment information to RallyUp — [P10, 00:53:45] Supporting Quotes "I trust UNICEF automatically. With RallyUp I'd need to verify who they are first. That's extra work most people won't do." — P1, 00:53:45 "Option A is a brand trust play. Option B is a UX trust play. For clicking pay, design trust matters more." — P5, 00:53:55 "A well-designed platform makes me trust the org more — it signals they take their donors seriously." — P4, 00:53:45 Recommendations • Explore how RallyUp can establish its own credibility on the campaign page, so donors who have never heard of the platform can quickly understand what it is and why they can trust it with their payment. • Consider how the legitimacy of the organisations using the platform can be made more visible to donors — surfacing signals that help donors feel confident before they reach the payment step. Mapped Research Questions – What factors impact their decision to take part in a fundraising event? – Where does RallyUp meet or not meet donor expectations? – What information do they expect/need to know about the fundraiser?

INSIGHT 5 Social proof — real-time donor feeds, public name recognition, and community visibility — is a giving accelerator, not a vanity feature Multiple participants described seeing other donors give in real time as a direct trigger for their own decision to give or give more. One participant explicitly mentioned, the visible presence of others in the chat was what converted her from observer to participant. Being named by the host caused her to give up a second time just to hear her name called again. These are not preferences about interface decoration — they are participation mechanics that produced measurable giving behaviour. The competitive and communal energy of a live event only travels online when donors can feel that others are in it with them. Observations ◦ P4 donated because a public donor feed made her not want to be excluded from the visible giving community — FOMO as a donation trigger — [P4, 00:05:00] ◦ P4 gave again during the same event after hearing her name called by the host — public recognition drove repeat in-event giving — [P4, 00:22:50] ◦ P7 named social visibility of who else was giving as one of her three decision criteria — [P7, 00:19:05] ◦ P9 described wanting to see the fundraising total climbing in real time as creating momentum and a sense of participation — [P9, 00:22:00] ◦ P3 identified the absence of a real-time running total as one of her top-three platform frustrations — [P3, 00:26:50] Supporting Quotes "A live donor feed showing names and amounts — that's the feature that would make me give more and come back." — P4,

00:55:20 "I donated because everyone else in the chat was. The public feed made me want to participate." — P4, 00:05:00 "Being named by the host made me feel seen — I gave again just to hear my name." — P4, 00:22:50

Recommendations

- Explore ways to make the collective momentum of a live event visible to donors as it unfolds — giving individuals a sense of participation in something larger than their own contribution.
- Consider how donors can be acknowledged in the moment during a live event, in a way that feels genuine rather than automated.

Mapped Research Questions

- What compels donors to participate in a fundraiser?
- What is the donor's mental model for a live event?
- What are undiscovered opportunities we should pursue?

INSIGHT 6 Financial transparency is a trust prerequisite for a segment of donors who will not give without it — and its absence triggers active suspicion, not neutrality

For several participants, particularly those who give frequently or in large amounts, the question of how their money is allocated is not an afterthought — it is a precondition for giving at all. P5 checks IRS 990 filings before donating. P1 named fund-usage breakdown as the single most common piece of missing information across all fundraisers she has used. What makes this especially significant is P5's observation that when this information is difficult to find, she does not simply move on — she assumes the organisation has something to hide. For this donor segment, the absence of transparency is not neutral; it actively undermines trust.

Observations

- P5 checks IRS 990 filings as part of her standard pre-donation evaluation — [P5, 00:11:30]
- P1 named fund-usage breakdown as the number-one piece of information missing from every fundraiser she has used — [P1, 00:20:00]
- P5 stated that information hard to find makes her wonder what is being hidden — [P5, 00:22:00]
- P3 named insufficient financial transparency as one of her three top frustrations across platforms — [P3, 00:26:50]
- P5 and P9 both named specific impact tiers as the most converting copy format — vague mission statements did not convert — [P9, 00:18:50]

Supporting Quotes

"How much of my money actually reaches the cause? No one tells me upfront." — P1, 00:20:00

"If the financial info isn't easy to find, I wonder what they're hiding." — P5, 00:21:20

"Specific impact claims convert me. Vague mission statements don't." — P9, 00:18:50

Recommendations

- Explore how campaign pages can surface what a donation actually does — moving beyond mission statements toward concrete, specific impact that donors can connect their contribution to.
- Consider making financial transparency information easy to access from the campaign page, so donors who need it do not have to leave the platform to find it.

Mapped Research Questions

- What information do they expect/need to know about the fundraiser?
- What factors impact their decision to take part in a fundraising event?
- Where does RallyUp meet or not meet donor expectations?

INSIGHT 7 Auction item descriptions are a revenue feature — insufficient detail causes direct and measurable bid refusal

Multiple participants stated they would not bid on items they could not properly evaluate due to insufficient details of the auction item. A separate but related

issue is that several participants were uncertain what placing a bid actually committed them to, particularly those new to online auctions. Without a clear understanding of the commitment, donors either avoided bidding or bid with hesitation — neither of which reflects the confident, competitive energy the auction format is designed to produce.

Observations

- P3 refused to bid on items with insufficient descriptions — no description equals no bid — [P3, 00:46:30]
- P7 selected auction items by description quality — a direct link between content quality and bidding intent — [P7, 00:47:15]
- P6 named vague prize descriptions as his top frustration across all fundraisers — [P6, 00:25:25]
- P10 asked aloud if pressing bid meant he was definitely paying — bid commitment ambiguity is a barrier for novice auction participants — [P10, 00:47:00]
- P6 stated he wanted to see the full auction catalogue before the event — previewing items pre-event would drive pre-event engagement — [P6, 00:55:20]

Supporting Quotes

- "I won't bid on something I can't properly evaluate. No description equals no bid." — P3, 00:46:30
- "I pick based on information. If an item has no description, it doesn't get my bid." — P7, 00:47:15
- "Is this like eBay? Am I locked in if I bid?" — P10, 00:47:00

Recommendations

- Require organisations to provide meaningful item descriptions before an auction item can be published. The quality of this information directly determines whether donors will bid.
- Make clear to donors what placing a bid means in terms of commitment, so they can participate with confidence rather than hesitation.
- Explore whether giving donors access to auction items before the event begins could drive earlier engagement and better-informed bidding during the event.

Mapped Research Questions – What is the donor's mental model for an auction, raffle and/or live event? – What do they expect to see and be able to do in these types of fundraisers? – Where can we simplify the experience?

INSIGHT 8 New-to-digital donors are a high-dropout segment whose barrier is unfamiliarity, not unwillingness — and onboarding content is the only intervention that reaches them

Three participants represented a new-to-digital donor profile: high willingness to give, strong social referral conversion, but persistent uncertainty at conventions that experienced online donors take for granted. One participant almost did not participate because she did not understand what would happen. Another described every moment of confusion as a near-exit. Both completed the tasks, but the critical question is how many similar donors do not complete in a real setting. The platform currently provides no mechanism to bridge the gap between what it assumes donors know and what first-time participants actually know. For this segment, clarity is the only thing standing between intent and action.

Observations

- P7 almost did not participate because she did not understand what was going to happen — [P7, 00:21:30]
- P10 stated explicitly that every moment of confusion was a near-exit — [P10, 00:55:20]
- P10 had no idea what a raffle entry meant in an online context — [P10, 00:20:00]
- P10 scrolled to the bottom of the campaign page looking for a how to participate option before reading any content — [P10, 00:31:50]
- P8 had a question

during the campaign and could not find a contact option, creating a moment of near-dropout — [P8, 00:20:00] Supporting Quotes "I almost didn't participate because I didn't understand what was going to happen." — P7, 00:21:30 "Every time I felt confused I thought about leaving." — P10, 00:55:20 "I had no idea what a raffle entry meant online. An FAQ would have answered my questions." — P10, 00:20:00

Recommendations

- Explore ways to help first-time donors understand how a fundraiser works before they are required to make any decisions — reducing the cognitive load at the point of participation.
- Ensure donors have an easy way to get a question answered during a campaign. An unanswered question at a critical moment is a dropout, not a delay.

Mapped Research Questions

- Who is the user and what is their journey like?
- What information do they expect/need to know about the fundraiser?
- Where does RallyUp meet or not meet donor expectations?
- Where can we simplify the experience?

Section 2: Key Findings

The following findings capture structured, factual, or lightly synthesised data that is important for context and does not require the interpretive depth of the insight format.

KEY FINDING 1 Discovery Channels: How Donors Find Fundraisers

No participant discovered a fundraiser independently through a platform or search engine. All 10 arrived via a social or personal referral channel. The following describes the full discovery landscape:

- Direct personal ask (text, WhatsApp, direct message) — P2, P6, P8. The most converting channel; specificity of the request removes comparison friction entirely.
- Social media post from a known person (Instagram story, Facebook post) — P1, P4. FOMO and social belonging are the primary triggers, not cause alignment.
- Email from a trusted organisation — P3, P5. Effective only where a prior donor relationship already exists; described as the trigger, not the reason for giving.
- Hyperlocal community channel (Nextdoor, church bulletin, word-of-mouth) — P7, P8. Geographic and relational proximity produces the highest-trust discovery signal.
- Instagram ad (high-quality creative) — P9. Production quality of the ad functioned as an org trust proxy.
- Proxy discovery (wife/colleague forwarded) — P10. Complete trust delegation to the social intermediary; the platform never earned direct trust.

Observations

- P6's ask included a specific dollar amount — specificity of the ask dramatically reduces friction compared to open-ended requests — [P6, 00:08:50]
- P2 had no prior concept of virtual live fundraising events — he was entirely unaware the format existed — [P2, 00:04:50]

Supporting Quotes

- "The personal ask is what made the difference — if it had been an ad I'd have scrolled past it." — P2, 00:08:40
- "The ask was specific: Can you put in 0? A specific amount makes it easier to say yes." — P6, 00:08:50

Mapped Research Questions

- Who is the user and what is their journey like?
- How do they discover and engage with fundraisers?
- What motivates them?

KEY FINDING 2 Donor Motivation Profiles: Four Distinct Giving Triggers

Across the study, four distinct giving motivation profiles emerged. These profiles are not mutually exclusive, but each represents a different primary trigger for giving:

- Cause-connected donor (P1, P3, P5, P9):

Motivated primarily by alignment with the cause and trust in the organisation's impact. Impact reporting and financial transparency are the primary retention signals for this profile.

- Socially-driven donor (P4, P7): Motivated primarily by community participation, social visibility, and belonging. Live donor feeds, public name recognition, and peer giving visibility are the highest-engagement features for this profile.
- Competitive donor (P6): Motivated primarily by the game mechanics of competitive giving — bidding, winning, countdown timers. Whether he wins directly determines his experience quality, regardless of cause alignment.
- Proximity / local donor (P8): Motivated exclusively by geographic and relational proximity. National or abstract causes do not move him; hyperlocal impact specificity is the only effective message. Observations
 - P6 explicitly stated his best fundraising experience is directly correlated to whether he won — [P6, 00:22:50]
 - P8 did not respond to cause framing — only to local impact — [P8, 00:23:00]
 - P9 distinguishes between scheduled giving (rational, values-led) and live events (spontaneous, emotion-led) — representing both cause-connected and socially-driven modes — [P9, 00:04:40]

Mapped Research Questions – What motivates them? – What compels donors to participate or not participate in a fundraiser? – Who is the user and what is their journey like?

KEY FINDING 3 Platform Friction Inventory: Checkout and Navigation Issues

Tasks 1 and 2 produced a consistent set of friction points across participants, ranked here by the number of participants who encountered or named each issue:

- Mandatory account creation mid-checkout — encountered by 10/10 participants; named as the primary friction by 7/10.
- Physical address form for a digital ticket — named as unexpected or unnecessary by P1, P3, P4, P9.
- 'Delivery method' label for a digital ticket — named as confusing by P3, P4, P9.
- Raffle section visual prominence — P2, P7, P10 scrolled past without finding it on the first pass.
- Bid commitment ambiguity — P8, P10 uncertain whether placing a bid constituted a guaranteed payment.
- 'Make anonymously' option — P4, P8, P10 confused by the option or did not understand its implications.
- Tip prompt unexpectedness — P2 felt it was pushy; P5 noted it should be opt-in rather than opt-out.
- No current bid visibility from other donors — P1 named the absence of competing bids as a gap in the auction experience.

Supporting Quotes "I'm buying a digital ticket — why do you need my home address?" — P4, 00:38:50 "Each step that surprises me costs me a little bit of trust." — P7, 00:39:40

Mapped Research Questions – What about the experience made it easy or difficult to complete the transaction? – Where does RallyUp meet or not meet donor expectations? – Where can we simplify the experience?